

# WE ALL FALL DOWN



Too much money but too little talent seem to be the reason for Bollywood's floundering performance

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Six months, 33 film releases and just three certified hits. That is how Bollywood's report card for 2008 reads. Compare this with last year, when the number of films released in the first half was 21 and the number of hits was six. Half way into the year and only three films, *Race*, *Jodhaa Akbar* and *Jannat*, have been able to cross the hit film mark. The 27 others either sank without a trace or just recovered their cost. From the Rs 4-crore *Bombay to Ban-gkok* to the Rs 40-crore *Tashan*, none has been able to stir the box office out of its deep slumber. Ajay Devgan's Rs 25-crore directorial debut *U, Me Aur Hum* and

Rakesh Roshan's Rs 18-crore home production *Krazzy 4*, expected to bring in the cash, managed average business. While *U, Me Aur Hum* got audiences to the theatre because of the star presence and aggressive publicity, part of the reason for *Krazzy 4*'s decent opening were the two item numbers by Shah Rukh Khan and Hrithik Roshan. Unfortunately once people realised that the songs shielded a flimsy script, the numbers dwindled.

On the other hand, the two biggest hits of the year, *Race* and *Jannat*, delivered exactly what they promised.

**HALLA BOL, a social commentary, was loud, long and a box-office loser**



**TASHAN has great style, but little else to recommend it**

The Rs 35-crore *Race* was promoted as a dance, drama and action film. Though critics weren't particularly kind to the film, the viewers were. What worked in *Jannat*'s favour was its cost of production. The film made on a budget of Rs 5 to 6 crore was sold to Percept Picture Company for about Rs 10 crore. People were in the midst of Indian Premiere League (IPL) and its betting angle also drew viewers in droves.

Optimists blamed it on the IPL, which provided more drama than the good old Bollywood. But the cynics say that this mass tanking is because the corporates have entered the film business. Creativity has thus taken a backseat and the prime motive is to play the numbers game by releasing multiple films. Instead of making films, they are just doing business and selling movies—good, bad or average—quite convincingly. "Packaging is the king today. But if the content is hollow you can only sprint with the film, and can't run the marathon," says Shailendra Singh, managing director, Percept Picture Company. The marketing bug seems to have bitten old timers like Yash Raj Films (YRF) and Roshan's Filmkraft too. Both production houses, known for telling good stories, bombarded the viewers with promos of *Tashan* and *Krazzy 4* without giving a glimpse of the film. As the head of a production house points out, "The audience is very smart.